Tini's Mac and Cheese

Main dishes | Oven

Before you start

Equipment: 9×13-inch baking dish and skillet. Oven: 350°F, then broil. Bake: 25-30 minutes; broil about 2 minutes. Cheese and seasoning are each divided before cooking.

Ingredients

Matching letters and colors = one prep bowl. Charcoal = keep separate.

Bowl A - Cheese mixture; divide after mixing

Bowl B - Seasoning mixture; divide in half

- [ ] 1 lb cavatappi, cooked
- [ ] 16 oz mozzarella, grated [Bowl A]
- [ ] 16 oz Colby Jack, grated [Bowl A]

- [ ] 8 oz Cheddar, grated [Bowl A]
- [ ] 1 tsp garlic powder [Bowl B]
- [ ] 1 tsp smoked paprika [Bowl B]
- [ ] 1/2 tsp salt [Bowl B]
- [ ] 1/2 tsp pepper [Bowl B]
- [ ] 3 Tbsp butter
- [ ] 3 Tbsp flour
- [ ] 1 (12 oz) can evaporated milk
- [ ] 2 cups heavy cream
- [ ] 1 Tbsp Dijon mustard

1. Prepare pasta and divided ingredients

1. Heat the oven to 350°F and grease a 9×13-inch baking dish. Cook and drain 1 lb cavatappi.

2. Mix 16 oz grated mozzarella, 16 oz grated Colby Jack, and 8 oz grated Cheddar. Divide into two equal 20 oz portions: one for the sauce, one for layering.

3. Mix 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1/2 tsp salt, and 1/2 tsp pepper. Divide this seasoning mixture in half.

2. Make the cheese sauce

1. Melt 3 Tbsp butter in a skillet. Stir in 3 Tbsp flour and half the seasoning mixture (equivalent to 1/2 tsp garlic powder, 1/2 tsp paprika, 1/4 tsp salt, and 1/4 tsp pepper). Cook 3-5 minutes, until paste-like.

2. Whisk in one 12 oz can evaporated milk until thickened.

3. Add 2 cups heavy cream, the remaining half of the seasoning mixture, and 1 Tbsp Dijon mustard.

4. Gradually melt in the 20 oz cheese portion reserved for the sauce. Stir in the cooked cavatappi.

3. Layer and bake

1. Spread half the macaroni mixture in the baking dish. Add half the reserved layering cheese (10 oz). Repeat with the remaining macaroni and remaining 10 oz cheese.

2. Bake 25-30 minutes, until bubbly. Broil about 2 minutes to brown the top.